

USB survival tool

How cool is a USB Swiss Army Memory Stick!

Victorinox, the world's favourite creator of the multifunctional Swiss Army knife, has joined hands with flash memory manufacturer Swissbit to create a USB memory stick Swiss knife. The knife, immortalised in popular literature and films, will also have the usual assortment of quality tools such as the saw, the corkscrew and a tin opener, along with 64 MB and 128 MB USB memory stick options.

It debuted at the much-liked CeBIT tech fair at Hanover, Germany held March. Here is how



you can use it: Suppose you are on a jungle safari carrying your favourite Victorinox knife, and you are also carrying your laptop, and you are stranded, and maybe you are still alive, thanks to your survival tin food or the absence of wild animals, you may be able to exploit the memory stick to its fullest. Just connect it to your laptop, and let GPS systems help you get back to civilisation.

Have more ideas on how to use the Swiss Army Knife USB memory stick? Write to us at readersletters@jasubhai.com. We will publish the top three innovative reasons in next month's Digit.

No more freebies, please

Our guess is that the US Department of Defence has not even spoken to, or has not been influenced by its Indian counterpart, which, allegedly, does not cringe at earning a little money on the side, even coffin deals.

Why would the officials at the Defence Department otherwise tell Microsoft not to send free copies of their Office suite to army officers. The department is not alone. The army itself has issued a letter to Microsoft's chairman Bill Gates asking his com-



pany to desist from offering free software to army personnel.

The letter also points out that army personnel may unknowingly violate ethics rules and regulations. The army has asked all its officers to return the freebies.

For its part, Microsoft says the software was sent "without obligation". Hmmm, is this the same company that fought the

US government tooth and nail, claiming it does not want to kill others in the market by institutionalising its monopolistic outlook?

Hitachi ships 400 GB giant

What would you call the Hitachi 400 GB Deskstar 7k400? OK, let's see. Giant? Nah. Leviathan? Maybe, but it has a negative connotation. So, we thought we would settle for the serpentine Leviathan's arch mythological enemy—the Behemoth.

A quick calculation on what a 400 GB hard drive could hold:

- One lakh MP3 songs at 4 MB per song;
- 1 crore MS Word files at approximately 40 KB per file;
- 100-125 DVD movies at 3-4 GB per movie

Now, let us calculate how much time would we take to absorb all this data:

- Listening to all one lakh songs would take 6,666 hours or 278 days at a stretch.
- Reading all the MS Word files (assuming we take 15 minutes to read one file) at one stretch would take 2.5 million hours.
- To watch all the movies would take 625 hours at a stretch, assuming two hours per movie.

Our question, then, is: Who would want to buy a 400 GB hard drive? Hitachi says

the drive is aimed at the audio-visual market where the principal criteria for selecting a drive are size and cost per GB.

Besides, Hitachi informs us, the drive features a new industry standard AV feature known as Streaming Command Set used for optimising storage and retrieval procedure of content on a digital video recorder (DVR).

All that is great news. But our question still remains: Why would you want to buy this behemoth?



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In-store Wi-Fi hotspots

McDonald's is now offering Wi-Fi hotspots in the US. Bookstore chain, Barnes and Noble, plans to launch such services by September 2004, thus offering customers wireless Internet access in more public locations.

Legitimate music downloads

In a season where Napster 2.0 and the iTunes music download service have reported millions of legal music downloads, the Starbucks coffee chain now offers customers the chance to download and burn entire CD compilations as they drink coffee.



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Lindows

Lindows has been forced to pull out of the Netherlands, Belgium and Luxembourg after Microsoft got local courts to ban Lindows from the Benelux region on copyright and trademark infringement grounds. Lindows has also been slapped with a 100,000 Euro per day fine since Benelux users can still access the international Lindows site.

Peer-to-peer companies

Recent moves in the US state of California may make P2P-software making companies more responsible of the sort of content that is available through their software, and prevent them from releasing features that hide customers who deal in pornography or copyrighted material.